# SCRIPT: Amazon Alone

*Story Map version: 3 · Deslopped*

**[B01]**

The lodge sits on a brown river in the Brazilian Amazon, a few hours by boat from the city of Manaus. There's no road in. Everything arrives on the water: food, fuel, guests. Two long wooden boats knock gently against the dock below the dining hall.

Behind the lodge, a marked trail loops into the forest and back. Twenty minutes, the staff said. Stay on the path. Be back before dark.

So at dusk you go alone, in trail shoes and a light shirt, with your phone in one pocket and a plastic water bottle, half full, in your hand. Nothing else. No lighter. No knife. It's a twenty-minute walk.

For three days you've been listening for one animal. A jaguar. Part of you wants to see one, from the safety of a boat. Part of you checks the trees every time something moves.

**[B02]**

The path is easy at first. Red mud, roots worn smooth, little painted marks on the trunks. The light is already going green and thin.

Then, off to your left, something heavy breaks through the undergrowth. Not a bird. Not a monkey. Branches snap. Leaves shake. It's close, and it's big, and it doesn't stop.

Your mind fills in the rest before you can think. Spotted coat. Low shoulders. Teeth.

You run.

Not down the path. Away from the sound, straight into the trees, because that's where your legs take you. Leaves whip your face. The bottle bangs against your hip. Somewhere behind you the crashing stops, or maybe you just can't hear it over your own breathing.

**[B03]**

A minute. Maybe two. That's all it is.

Something catches your left shin mid-stride, a broken branch or a spiny stem, and pulls. It doesn't hurt yet. It just feels hot.

When you finally stop and bend over, gasping, the shin is wet and dark. A long cut, ragged at one end, running down toward your sock.

You straighten up and turn to go back to the path.

There is no path.

Trunks in every direction. Vines. Palms with long spines on their stems. The same green-grey wall wherever you look, and the light draining out of it. You turn a full circle, slowly, and nothing looks like the way you came.

You pull out your phone. No signal. Not one bar.

**[B04]**

The dark comes faster than you expected.

You could keep moving. The path has to be close. But in this light you can't see the ground, and the ground is roots, holes and those spined palms. A fall, a twisted ankle, a branch through the eye: any of those turns a bad night into something much worse.

Something you read once comes back, half-remembered. If you're lost, stop.

So you stop. You find the widest trunk nearby and put your back against it. At least nothing can come at you from behind.

**[B05]**

You shout first. "Hello!" Then louder. Then the lodge's name, again and again, until your throat burns.

Nothing answers except insects, millions of them, and then rain.

You hear it before you feel it, a roar spreading across the canopy far above you like applause. A lot of it never gets down to you. The leaves catch it. What does arrive comes in fat, heavy drops, splattering off leaves the size of plates.

You unscrew the bottle and hold it out. It fills slowly, drop by drop. You drink some. It's warm and tastes of leaves, and it's the best thing you've ever had.

Then you look at the shin.

With the phone's light you can see it properly: dirt in the cut, a sliver of bark near the top. You pour a little rainwater over it and pick the bark out with your fingernails. Then you tear a strip off the bottom of your sleeve and tie it around your leg. It isn't clean. It isn't a dressing. It's what you have.

The phone goes off to save the battery.

The rain keeps coming. You're soaked through, shirt, socks and shoes, but it isn't cold. It's warm, and that somehow makes it worse. There's no shivering to keep you busy. Just wet, and dark, and sounds. A rustle. A drip. Something that might be breathing, or might be you.

You don't sleep. Not really.

**[B06]**

Morning arrives as a dim green glow, as if the forest were slowly turning its lamps on.

Under the strip, the cut is still angry at the edges, a pink-red rim around it, and it stings when the air touches it. Could be healing. Could be something else. You tie the strip back on.

Your shoes squelch. They haven't dried and they're not going to. The phone won't turn on at all.

But it's daylight, and daylight changes things. You only ran for a minute or two. The path can't be more than a few hundred steps away. You just need to walk in a straight line, and you'll hit it.

You pick a direction, the one that feels most like the way you came, and go. Every few steps you snap a sapling, bending it over so the pale inside shows. If you need to come back, you'll follow your own trail.

You stop shouting. It hurts your throat and makes you thirsty, and by lunch you'll be eating at the lodge anyway.

**[B07]**

After an hour, the trail of snapped saplings stretches behind you and the forest ahead looks exactly the same. Same trunks. Same vines. Same green half-light.

You're watching the ground for the path when you see it.

A snake, lying in the brown leaves, just beside your right foot. Its pattern is so close to the leaf litter you'd have stepped on it if you'd looked up one second longer. Thick body. Broad, flat head. Not moving.

You don't move either.

Then, very slowly, you lift your foot and step back. And again. And again, until there are a few metres of forest between you.

Your heart is going so hard you can feel it in the cut on your leg.

A picture from some old film flashes into your head: the hero slicing the bite open and sucking the venom out. That's a myth, and a dangerous one. The World Health Organization says don't cut a bite, don't try to suck it out, and never tie a tight tourniquet. Keep the person still, remove anything tight in case of swelling, and get them to a health facility as fast as possible.

That last part is what stays with you. At one big hospital in this region, nearly nine in ten snakebite patients had been bitten on the leg or foot. Yours are in soaked trail shoes and wet socks. And the advice is to keep still and be carried out. Out here, there's nobody to carry you.

You walk on. Slower now, looking at every step.

**[B08]**

By the middle of the day, the bottle is empty and the rain has stopped.

Thirst is a strange thing in a place this wet. Water drips from everything. Your clothes are full of it. And your mouth is dry.

In a hollow between two roots, you find a pool. It's clear. You can see the leaves at the bottom. It looks cleaner than the rainwater did.

You kneel down beside it, and you don't drink.

Clear doesn't mean safe. You can't tell what's in water by looking at it, or smelling it, or tasting it. And you have no fire, so you can't boil it. One mouthful of the wrong water could make you sick out here, a long way from help.

You stand up, thirstier than before, and keep walking.

**[B09]**

Ahead of you, a sapling is bent over, its pale inside showing.

Then another one, a few steps beyond it.

You stop and stare, and for a few seconds your brain refuses to understand what your eyes are telling it.

You snapped that. That's yours.

You've been walking toward your own trail. All morning you've been going straight, or what felt like straight, and you've curved right back across your own path without ever feeling the turn.

This isn't carelessness. It's how people work. In a study in Germany, people tried to walk a straight line through a forest. When the sun was out, they kept a straight line. When clouds hid the sun, they walked in circles without even noticing. Without the sun or a distant landmark to steer by, small errors in our sense of direction keep adding up, and "straight ahead" slowly bends.

You look up. Above you, the canopy blocks almost all of the sun. There's no sun to steer by. There hasn't been all day.

All that confidence this morning, every step of it, was a curve.

**[B10]**

You sit down on a root, and for a while you don't do anything at all.

Search and rescue advice for lost people is simple: stop. Stay put. A person who keeps wandering makes the search area bigger and the search slower. That advice works when someone is looking for you. Someone probably is, but you don't know where they're

looking, and you don't even know which direction the lodge is.

And waiting isn't free. The shin feels hotter than it did this morning. Your feet ache from the wet.

So you make a different kind of plan. One that doesn't rely on your sense of direction, because your sense of direction has just been caught lying.

Water runs downhill. Small streams run into bigger ones. And the lodge sits on a river. The same kind of advice that says stop also says that if you really do have to move, following a stream or river can often lead you to people.

But not now, not with the light going. Tonight, you rest and save your strength. At first light, you go downhill until you find running water. Then you follow it the way it flows. No more guessing. No more wandering. If you move again, you move with a method.

**[B11]**

The second night is longer than the first. Rain comes again, and you fill the bottle again. The shin throbs in time with your heartbeat. You lie against your tree and listen to the forest and think about how sure you were this morning. You don't make that mistake twice.

**[B12]**

At first light, you go downhill.

It's slow. The slope is slick, and you go down some of it sitting. But the ground keeps falling away, and after a while you hear it, a low steady trickle, and then you see it. A stream, brown and quick, no wider than a road lane.

You follow it.

Where the banks are tangled, you step down into the water and wade. Your feet have been wet for about two days now. Every step sends a sharp, raw ache up through your soles, and you start counting steps just to keep going.

Around mid-morning you stop to look at the shin, and this time there's no question. The redness has spread well beyond the edges of the cut. The skin around it is hot and tight and swollen, and the strip of sleeve is stuck to something cloudy and yellow. It hurts more than it did yesterday, a deep, pulsing hurt.

The bottle is empty. There's no rain. There's no fire.

You stand there looking at the stream. Then you fill the bottle and drink. You know it's a risk. Thirst is a risk too, and right now it's the more certain one.

**[B13]**

The stream gets wider. The banks open out. The light changes, first to a paler green, then gold, and then, suddenly, open sky.

You step out of the trees onto a muddy bank, and in front of you is a river. Broad, brown, slow. The sun is on your face for the first time in two days.

Every part of you wants to crawl back into the shade and lie down. You don't. You stay out on the open bank where you can be seen, because that's the whole point of being here.

**[B14]**

At first it's just a buzz, so low you think it's another insect.

Then it's an engine.

A long wooden boat comes around the bend upriver, slow, close to the far bank, two people in it scanning the trees.

You wave both arms. You shout with whatever's left of your voice. It comes out as a croak, but you keep doing it, waving and croaking, until one of the figures points and the boat swings toward you.

**[B15]**

They pull you in. Someone gives you water from a sealed bottle and you drink it too fast and cough.

The boat turns downstream. One bend. That's it. One bend in the river, and there's the dock, and the dining hall, and the boats you saw on the first evening.

The guide at the tiller looks back at the mouth of your stream, then at you.

"Less than a kilometre," he says. About half a mile.

They started looking at first light on the second morning, he tells you. Up and down the loop trail, calling your name, all day and all of the next. And all that time, you were walking in silence, snapping saplings, sure you were heading out. Never more than about a kilometre from the path.

You think about that for a long time.

The jungle didn't trap you. Your senses did.

**[B16]**

At the lodge, someone cleans and dresses the cut properly, and later a doctor puts you on antibiotics for the infection. Your feet take days to stop hurting. Doctors call it tropical immersion foot, and it can come from feet kept wet in warm water for two days or more.

Some of the risks don't end when you're rescued. For weeks after you get home, any fever means getting checked by a doctor. That stream water could still make you ill. There's an infection called leptospirosis, carried in water contaminated by animal urine, that can get in through a cut like yours, and it can show up anywhere from two days to a month later. And

malaria usually takes ten to fifteen days after an infected mosquito's bite to show itself.

As for the jaguar, it was always the long shot. Across the whole Brazilian Amazon, researchers have counted about one attack on people a year. You never find out what was crashing through the undergrowth that evening. What hurt you was the running.

So if you're ever lost: stop. Stay where you can be found. And never trust "straight" when you can't see the sun.